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ORIGINAL EMPIRICAL RESEARCH

Customer satisfaction: A multi-level framework

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Abstract
Customer satisfaction (CSAT) is a central construct in theory and practice; yet its role as a strategic resource is often underappreciated. This article synthesizes the conceptual foundations, measurement approaches, empirical findings, and managerial applications of CSAT research. This article defines CSAT as a post-consumption evaluative judgment of whether customers receive the promised value, and distinguishes it from related constructs such as service quality, engagement, loyalty, experience, and value. Drawing on multiple scales and a comparative study across consumer demographics, we demonstrate that widely used CSAT measures exhibit strong convergent validity. A historical review of the evolution of CSAT research highlights the multi-level nature of the resulting frameworks, providing individual-, firm-, and industry-level insights. Furthermore, we use a large-scale dataset of more than 285 million ratings across 1,126 brands to replicate and extend prior meta-analytic evidence and show that CSAT is robustly associated with customer mindset metrics, accounting outcomes, and stock market performance. Finally, we develop micro-, meso- and macro-level conceptual frameworks and outline a forward-looking, multi-level research agenda to revitalize CSAT scholarship and practice.

Keywords Customer satisfaction · Multi-level framework · Financial performance · Strategy

There is only one boss. The customer. And he can fire everybody in the company from chairman on down, simply by spending his money somewhere else.

—Sam Walton, Founder of Walmart.

Any business that has delighted customers has a sales-force out there that you don't have to pay. You don't see them, but they are talking to people all the time.

—Warren Buffett, Founder of Berkshire Hathaway.

There are many ways to center a business. You can be competitor focused, you can be product focused, you can be technology focused, you can be business model focused, and there are more. But in my view, obsessive customer focus is by far the most protective. If you're competitor-focused, you have to wait until there is a competitor doing something. Being customer-focused allows you to be more pioneering.

—Jeff Bezos, Founder of Amazon.

As three of the most successful business founders assert, a customer-focused strategy is foundational to a firm's enduring success[1]; it enables a company to align strategy through customer satisfaction (CSAT) (Mittal, 2023, May 1; Rust et al., 1995) and to create value for customers, employees, and shareholders (Anderson & Sullivan, 1993; Evanschitzky et al., 2011; Fornell, 1992). Given CSAT's centrality to a firm's strategy, this article provides a descriptively comprehensive

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[1] The quotes are from www.brainyquote.com. The collective market cap of the three companies exceeded $4.1 trillion on July 17, 2025 based on www.finance.yahoo.com.

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and theoretically integrative multi-level review of extant CSAT research to promote its adoption and use among executives and to revitalize the quantity and quality of research among scholars.

Treating customer satisfaction as a theoretical construct, a measurable variable, a robust research stream, and an organizing framework for developing and implementing strategy, we present a multi-level framework to understand CSAT scholarship at a micro (individual), meso (firm), and macro (industry, societal) level. In addition to providing a descriptive review, we raise critical issues and provide directions for future research as well as ways to implement a customer-focused firm strategy. We especially focus on micro-, meso- and macro-level insights and research opportunities. The goal is to spark new research ideas among scholars, both new to and experienced with CSAT research. For executives, this article provides a roadmap to measure CSAT, predict critical firm outcomes, and develop a customer-focused strategy plan. Regulators and policymakers gain new insights for managing consumer and employee welfare and other societal outcomes. In the next section, we lay the conceptual groundwork for unpacking the core construct's construction, measurement, operationalization, and comparison with related constructs.

Customer satisfaction (CSAT): Definition, measurement & operationalization

Definition

We define customer satisfaction as a post-consumption, evaluative judgment that summarizes the extent to which customers perceive they have received the value promised by a product or service acquired. This definition echoes prior definitions (see Table 1) and highlights several key points.

Post-consumption evaluation Complementing the emphasis on pre-purchase decisions in consumer behavior (Robertson & Kassarjian, 1991), CSAT focuses on the post-purchase period, *after* a consumer has acquired and consumed an offering. Strategically, CSAT enables firms to understand the elements of value creation for customers, guide product/service design for an improved consumption experience, and grow sales through repurchase, recommendation, pricing power, revenue, and margins.

Transactional and cumulative consumption When consuming an offering over multiple occasions (e.g., driving a car, going to a restaurant many times), customers can express satisfaction with specific transactions and/or their

Table 1 Definitions of customer satisfaction by different scholars

Article	Definition
Howard and Sheth (1969, p. 145)	The buyer's cognitive state of being adequately or inadequately rewarded for the sacrifices he has undergone.
Hunt (1977, p. 459)	An evaluation rendered that the [consumption] experience was at least as good as it was supposed to be.
Oliver (1981, p. 27)	The summary psychological state resulting when the emotion surrounding disconfirmed expectations is coupled with the consumer's prior feelings about the consumption experience.
Westbrook and Reilly (1983, p. 256)	An emotional response to the experiences provided by, associated with particular products or services purchased, retail outlets, or even molar patterns of behavior such as shopping and buyer behavior, as well as the overall marketplace.
Tse and Wilton (1988, p. 204)	The consumer's response to the evaluation of the perceived discrepancy between prior expectations and the actual performance of the product as perceived after its consumption.
Fornell (1992, p. 11)	Customer satisfaction is defined as a customer's overall post purchase evaluation.
Anderson and Sullivan (1993, p. 126)	A post-purchase evaluation of product quality given prepurchase expectations.
Giese and Cote (2000, p. 15)	Consumer satisfaction is: • A summary affective response of varying intensity. The exact type of affective response and the level of intensity likely to be experienced must be explicitly defined by a researcher depending on the context of interest. • With a time-specific point of determination and limited duration. The researcher should select the point of determination most relevant for the research questions and identify the likely duration of the summary response. It is reasonable to expect that consumers may consciously determine their satisfaction response when asked by a researcher; therefore, timing is most critical to ascertain the most accurate, well-formed response. • Directed toward focal aspects of product acquisition and/or consumption. The researcher should identify the focus of interest based on the managerial or research question they face. This may include a broad or narrow range of acquisition or consumption activities/issues.
Oliver (1997, p. 13)	A judgment that a product/service feature, or the product or service itself, provided (or is providing) a pleasurable level of consumption-related fulfillment, including levels of under- or over-fulfillment.

cumulative experience (Anderson & Fornell, 1994). Scholars have measured CSAT transactionally after an airport visit and cumulatively with health insurance (Fernandes et al., 2022). Transaction-level CSAT helps firms fine-tune offerings through customer experience design, while cumulative CSAT enables long-term strategic planning.

Overall- and attribute-level models According to Oliver (2010, 2014), early models focused on expectations and their disconfirmation at an overall level while later models conceptualized CSAT as an outcome of performance evaluations of multiple attributes. Scholars have proposed models to measure CSAT at an attribute level (e.g., styling, roominess, safety) to predict overall CSAT (e.g., Mittal et al., 1998). These models can enable strategic prioritization of resources for implementing a customer-focused strategy (Mittal et al., 2021; Rust et al., 1995).

Multiple antecedents and correlates CSAT judgments result from multiple antecedents and correlates, such as attribute-level performance (LaTour & Peat, 1979; Mittal et al., 1998), expectation–disconfirmation (Oliver, 1980), emotions (Mano & Oliver, 1993), social norms (Cadotte et al., 1987), regret (Tsiros & Mittal, 2000), consumer attributions (Folkes, 1988), and relative equity (Oliver & Swan, 1989). Firms use these insights to design products and services with the right attribute mix while addressing customers' social and emotional needs (Oliver, 1993). While overall CSAT judgments are primarily driven by attribute expectations, performance, and disconfirmation, other constructs provide additional explanatory power or contingencies.

Measurement and operationalization

The expansive history of CSAT shows multiple ways of measuring and operationalizing it. This section provides a measurement overview, including key scales, while also distinguishing CSAT from seemingly related but conceptually distinct constructs.

CSAT is typically measured with single- or multi-item scales administered via a survey to users of a product or service (for details, see Mittal & Frennea, 2012). Table 2 shows an illustrative (not exhaustive) list of single- and multi-item CSAT scales. CSAT scales are ordinal in nature using 3, 5, 7, and 10 points with anchors such as "dissatisfied/satisfied" or "low/high." In practice, scales are treated as interval scales with studies frequently reporting and using average scores.

While earlier studies used multi-item scales, later studies began using single-item scales when commercial datasets from firms became accessible. For example, Mittal and Kamakura (2001) used a single-item, 5-point scale from an automotive company. Single-item scales have practical advantages, such as ease of administration, increased response rate, and lower survey costs (Mittal & Frennea, 2010). Research evaluating the reliability, validity, and predictive ability of single- versus multi-item scales shows that they are equivalent (Drolet & Morrison, 2001). Today, single-item CSAT scales have virtually replaced multi-item scales in research and practice.

CSAT is primarily measured at an individual level used in most micro-level, consumer behavior studies (e.g., Tsiros & Mittal, 2000). In the field, firms measure CSAT by surveying their current customers (Mittal & Frennea, 2010, 2012). At the meso level, CSAT measures can be aggregated at a customer group or firm level to draw conclusions by linking CSAT to financial performance (Bowman & Narayandas, 2001). For macro-level measures at the industry or economy level, firm-level scores can be aggregated to draw conclusions (Fornell et al., 1996).

Thus, individual-level CSAT scores can be aggregated and compared at many levels, though they lose measurement granularity and dispersion across individual units may be ignored. Studies incorporating second and third moments can provide deeper insights for research and practice.

Empirical evaluation of CSAT scales

Because a typical published study uses only one scale, a comparative evaluation of the different scales as shown in Table 2 is precluded. Demonstrating the extent to which different CSAT scales are correlated can enable scholars to interchangeably use the scales to fit their research goals.

We administered a subset of these scales (randomized within subject) to a sample of 1,003 consumers recruited from Prolific. As we describe in Web Appendix A, each respondent selected a brand from one of the four randomly assigned categories (laptops, banks, automobile, or mobile service) they currently use or are most familiar with. Next, they rated their satisfaction with the brand using different CSAT scales and provided demographics.

As Table 3 shows, the scales are strongly and positively correlated (r's range from 0.54 to 0.89; all $p<0.01$). The principal component analysis in Web Appendix A indicates that all scales loaded on a single factor. These results are reassuring on many fronts. First, scholars and firms can use the different CSAT scales interchangeably depending on their research goals and context. Second, scholars can use single-item scales, reducing the cost of data collection, increasing response rate, and garnering larger sample sizes required for reproducible research conclusions. Third, scholars can generalize results across studies that have historically utilized different scales. For example, research has replicated the link between CSAT and abnormal stock returns using a 3-point scale (Malshe et al., 2020) and

Table 2 Customer satisfaction (CSAT) measurement scales

Panel A: Multi-item CSAT measures	
Source	Scale Items
Oliver (1980)	(1 = "strongly disagree," 7 = "strongly agree") 1. I am satisfied with my decision to get or not to get a flu shot. 2. If I had to do it all over again, I would feel differently about the flu shot program. 3. My choice to get or not to get a flu shot was a wise one. 4. I feel bad about my decision concerning the flu shot. 5. I think that I did the right thing when I decided to get or not to get the flu shot. 6. I am not happy that I did what I did about the flu shot.
Churchill and Surprenant (1982)	The following satisfaction measures were used (Items Y9–Y13 in paper): 1. Attribute-specific (beliefs): Participants rated specific attributes (e.g., *plant height*, *leaf color*, *flower size*, *disease resistance*) as "strongly agree," "neutral," or "strongly disagree." 2. Attribute-specific (affect): The attributes are evaluated for affective reactions using a like–dislike scale. 3. Global satisfaction (verbal): A single-item scale: "completely satisfied," "neutral," or "completely dissatisfied." 4. Global satisfaction (faces): A visual scale using a series of faces (from happy to unhappy). 5. Purchase probability: How likely it is that you would purchase _____ when they are available on the market? (0 = very unlikely, 50 = don't know, 100 = almost certain). (This item was later dropped because of poor reliability).
Singh (1991)	Six-point scale (6 = very satisfied, 1 = very dissatisfied) 1. With my doctor's personal concern for me, I feel … 2. With my doctor's willingness to explain reasons for medical treatment, I feel … 3. With my doctor's medical abilities, I feel … 4. With my doctor's choice of hospitals, I feel … 5. With my doctor's ability to see me on time, I feel … 6. With my doctor's costs of medical visits, I feel …
Oliver (2006)	Eight items were used to measure customer satisfaction (1 = "strongly disagree," 7 = "strongly agree") 1. Expectations (+): I expected this product to be excellent. 2. Expectations (–): My expectations of this product were very low. (reverse-coded) 3. Performance (+): This product has performed very well. 4. Performance (–): This product has performed very poorly. (reverse-coded) 5. Disconfirmation (+): This product has exceeded my expectations. 6. Disconfirmation (0): This product has performed exactly as I had expected. 7. Disconfirmation (–): This product has fallen short of my expectations. (reverse-coded) 8. Satisfaction (the anchor): I am satisfied with my choice of this product. 9. Dissatisfaction: I am dissatisfied with my choice of this product. (reverse-coded)
Panel B: Single-item CSAT scales	
Source	Single-Item Scales
Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	"Overall, how satisfied are you with [brand/product]?"(1 = "not at all satisfied," 10 = "very satisfied")
Mittal et al. (1998)	Study 1 (medical care): Overall satisfaction with the medical care at the primary care provider's office (l = "very dissatisfied," 5 = "very satisfied"). Study 2 (new car buyers): Overall satisfaction on a 10-point scale (1 = "very dissatisfied," 10 = "completely satisfied") Study 3 (automotive vehicle ownership experience): Overall satisfaction on a 10-point scale (10 = "completely satisfied," 1 = "completely dissatisfied")
Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	"Based on your ownership experience, how would you rate your satisfaction with this vehicle's manufacturer?" 5 = "very satisfied," 4 = "somewhat satisfied," 3 = "neither satisfied nor dissatisfied," 2 = "somewhat dissatisfied," 1 = "very dissatisfied"
Bowman and Narayandas (2004)	Overall, how would you describe your satisfaction with [vendor]? Five-point scale anchored by "highly dissatisfied" and "highly satisfied"
Mittal et al. (2021)	Taking their entire experience into account, participants rated the supplier (1 = "extremely dissatisfied," 7 = "extremely satisfied")
Panel C: National/commercial indices	
Source	Single-Item Scale
ACSI (American Customer Satisfaction Index) Fornell (1992); Fornell et al. (1996)	1. Overall, how satisfied are you with [brand/product]? 1 = "not at all satisfied," 10 = very satisfied") 2. To what extent has [brand/product] fallen short of or exceeded your expectations? (1 = "fell short," 10 = "exceeded expectations") 3. How well does [brand/product] compare with your ideal company/product? (1 = "not very close," 10 = "very close to ideal")

Table 2 (continued)

YouGov BrandIndex Malshe et al. (2020)	The number of customers who have answered yes to the question, "Of which of the following brands would you say that you are a 'satisfied customer'?" The number of customers who have answered yes to the question, "Of which of the following brands would you say that you are a 'dissatisfied customer'?" Because customers are allowed to be indifferent, customer satisfaction and dissatisfaction measures are not merely the mathematical inverse of each other.
Panel D: Loyalty intentions	
Repurchase Intent Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	"Based on your ownership experience, how likely are you to purchase a vehicle made by Company X at your next purchase occasion?" 5 = "very likely," 4 = "somewhat likely," 3 = "neither likely nor unlikely," 2 = "somewhat unlikely," 1 = "very unlikely"
Word of Mouth (WOM) Oliver (2006) Anderson (1998) Richins (1983)	Oliver (2006) About how many people have you talked to about the good things or bad things about your car? ___ Did you tell these people mostly positive or mostly negative things about the car? (1= "mostly negative," 7 = "mostly positive") Anderson (1998): The number of individuals spoken to about recent experiences with quality. Richins (1983): Measure negative WOM as the act of telling at least one friend or acquaintance about the dissatisfaction.
Intent to recommend Keiningham et al. (2007) Oliver (2006)	Keiningham et al. (2007) 1. "Six/twelve months from now, how likely are you to still be using (Company or Brand X)?" 5 = "definitely will be using them," 4 = "probably will be using them," 3 = "might or might not be using them," 2 = "probably will not be using them," 1 = "definitely will not be using them" 2. "How likely would you be to recommend (Company/Brand X) to friends and colleagues?" 5 = "definitely would recommend them," 4 = "probably would recommend them," 3 = "might or might not recommend them," 2 = "probably would not recommend them," 1 = "definitely would not recommend them" 3. "Of the following list of statements, please select the one that comes closest to your feelings (regarding Company or Brand X)" 5 = "I prefer them to all the other (firms/brands in category)," 4 = "they are one of a few I prefer to other (firms/brands in category)," 3 = "they are acceptable, but I have no particular preference for them," 2 = "I somewhat prefer other (firms/brands in category)," 1 = "I strongly prefer other (firms/brands in category)" Oliver (2006) Did you recommend that these people: 1 = "not buy the car," 7 = "buy the car"
Willingness to pay more Anderson (1996) Homburg et al. (2005)	Anderson (1996); "If other brands remain at the same prices, how much can raise its price before you would not choose another the next time you buy?" Respondents provide an answer in percentage terms. Homburg et al. (2005) Participants were asked the price they would be willing to pay for the restaurant visit.
Complaining/Praising Oliver (2006)	1. "I complained/praised to the dealership about the car": Yes or No 2. "If YES, how many times? 1, 2, 3, 4, 5+

10-point scale (Fornell et al., 2016). Fourth, we observe a strong positive cross-level correlation among the scales at the individual (Oliver, 1980, 2006), firm (Anderson & Sullivan, 1993; Keiningham et al., 2007), and industry (ACSI) levels.

We compared average CSAT scores across social class, age, political identity, gender, and ethnicity (see Table 4). In general, CSAT scores increase with social class, though not perfectly monotonically across all scales. CSAT scores are highest for respondents over 66 years of age and lowest for respondents aged 56–65 years for the Anderson and Sullivan (1993) and ACSI scales. Replicating Fernandes et al. (2022), CSAT scores are higher among Republicans than Democrats. For gender, male and female respondents show similar CSAT scores. In terms of ethnicity, Black respondents report the highest CSAT scores across all scales, with the "Other" ethnicity category showing the lowest scores. These exploratory sub-group differences suggest the need to generate novel theoretical and managerial insights at a more granular level. Research should explore whether some subgroups are more satisfied than others. Is satisfaction level due to differing antecedent evaluations (e.g., expectations, performance) or differences in satisfaction ratings? How do these differences differentially affect downstream outcomes?

CSAT versus other constructs

Over time, several constructs have evolved, including service quality, customer engagement, customer loyalty, and customer experience. We argue these constructs are seemingly related to CSAT but conceptually distinct. As such, examining their conceptual definition and measurement approach is critical to ensure appropriate usage of each construct.

CSAT versus service quality Service quality is defined as the "discrepancy between consumers' perceptions of services

Table 3 Correlations among customer satisfaction scales

	Anderson and Sullivan (1993) ‡	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001) ‡	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov‡
Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	*1.00*							
ACSI	0.79	*1.00*						
Oliver (1980)	0.76	0.63	*1.00*					
Oliver (2006 a)	0.80	0.69	0.89	*1.00*				
Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	0.80	0.68	0.81	0.83	*1.00*			
Oliver (2006 b)	0.78	0.67	0.76	0.81	0.80	*1.00*		
Keiningham et al. (2007)	0.79	0.68	0.79	0.83	0.85	0.83	*1.00*	
YouGov	0.64	0.54	0.69	0.70	0.75	0.65	0.71	*1.00*
Cronbach's alpha‡	N.A.	0.67	0.92	0.92	N.A.	0.92	0.84	N.A.

‡Cronbach's alphas are not reported for single-item scales.

Note: Sample of 1,003 customers obtained in April 2026. Customers rated a brand from a randomly assigned category (laptop, bank, auto, mobile service). All correlations are statistically significant ($p < 0.01$)

Scale Items Used for Analysis

Anderson and Sullivan (1993): Overall, how satisfied are you with the brand?

ACSI: (1) To what extent has the brand fallen short of or exceeded your expectations? and (2) How well does the brand compare with your ideal company/brand?

Oliver (1980): (1) I am satisfied with my decision to purchase this brand, (2) If I had it to do all over again, I would feel differently about this purchase, (3) My choice to purchase this brand was a wise one, (4) I feel bad about my decision concerning this purchase, (5) I think that I did the right thing when I decided to purchase this brand, (6) I am not happy that I did what I did about this purchase.

Oliver (2006 a): (1) My expectations of this brand were very low. (2) This brand has performed very well. (3) This brand has performed very poorly. (4) This brand has exceeded my expectations. (5) This brand has performed exactly as I had expected. (6) This brand has fallen short of my expectations. (7) I am satisfied with my choice of this brand. (8) I am dissatisfied with my choice of this brand.

Mittal and Kamakura (2001): Based on your experience, how likely are you to do business with the brand again?

Oliver (2006 b): (1) Around how many people have you talked to about the good things or bad things regarding the brand? (2) Did you tell these people mostly positive or mostly negative things about the brand? (3) Did you recommend that these people… (buy/not buy)

Keiningham et al. (2007): (1) Indicate your likelihood of engaging in following two items related to the brand: (i) Six to twelve months from now, how likely are you to still be using the brand, and (ii) How likely would you be to recommend the brand to friends and colleagues?, (2) Of the following list of statements, please select the one that comes closest to your feelings regarding the brand: (i) I strongly prefer other brands in the same product category, (ii) I somewhat prefer other brands in the same product category, (iii) the brand is acceptable but I have no particular preference for it, (iv) It is one of the few brands I prefer to other brands in the same product category, (v) I prefer the brand to all the other brands in the same product category.

YouGov: Would you say that you are a satisfied customer of the brand? (Yes/No)

offered by a particular firm and their expectations about firms offering such services" (Parasuraman et al., 1988, p. 14). SERVQUAL, a survey-based instrument measures service quality on five dimensions—reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy, and responsiveness—using the multi-item scale shown in Web Appendix B.

Bitner and Hubbert (1994) showed that service quality and CSAT are related but distinct constructs, with service quality best conceptualized as an antecedent of CSAT. Other studies have specifically demonstrated that "service," "after-sales service and support" or "ongoing service" are antecedent attributes of CSAT in business-to-business (Bowman & Narayandas, 2001; Mittal et al., 2021) and consumer (Mittal et al., 2004) settings. Confirming this notion, Bitner and Hubbert (1994) showed that even in the context of services, measuring CSAT with specific service encounters may be appropriate. Oliver's (2014, p. 183, Fig. 6.4) analysis indicated that service quality is an antecedent of CSAT. Thus, the accumulated evidence leads us to conclude that service quality is conceptually distinct and empirically correlated with CSAT, and is an antecedent of CSAT.

CSAT versus customer engagement According to van Doorn et al. (2010, p. 254), "customer engagement behaviors go beyond transactions, and may be specifically defined as a customer's behavioral manifestations that have a brand or firm focus, beyond purchase, resulting from motivational drivers." Similarly, Pansari and Kumar (2017) defined and operationalized customer engagement as buying, referring, influencing, and providing feedback (see Figs. 1 and 2). Kumar and Pansari (2016, p. 499) defined customer engagement as "the attitude, behavior, the level of connectedness among customers" and operationalized it using items such as purchases, referrals, influence, and knowledge. These definitions conceptualize customer engagement as intentions and behaviors that are

Table 4 Average CSAT using different scales disaggregated by demographic subgroups

Average CSAT for self-reported social class									
Social Class	No. of Obs.	Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov
Poor	95	6.47	5.60	4.95	4.85	3.69	4.47	3.42	1.70
Lower middle class	289	6.96	5.92	5.21	5.06	3.91	4.77	3.71	1.77
Middle class	481	7.53	6.30	5.32	5.27	4.16	5.22	3.94	1.84
Upper middle class	131	7.58	6.39	5.33	5.29	4.27	5.15	3.97	1.83
Average CSAT for self-reported age groups									
Age Group	No. of Obs.	Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov
Less than 25 years	93	7.30	6.07	5.11	5.10	4.01	4.90	3.79	1.83
26–35 years	291	7.20	6.16	5.25	5.16	4.03	5.00	3.83	1.79
36–55 years	469	7.34	6.19	5.31	5.21	4.14	5.08	3.89	1.82
56–65 years	93	6.78	5.59	4.97	4.93	3.80	4.76	3.56	1.74
Over 66 years	57	7.81	6.54	5.44	5.38	4.11	5.13	3.89	1.84
Average CSAT for self-reported political identity									
Political Identity	No. of Obs.	Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov
Strong Republican	77	7.77	6.60	4.85	4.87	4.07	5.36	3.85	1.83
Moderate Republican	140	7.74	6.60	5.48	5.41	4.35	5.35	4.08	1.88
Independent	291	7.20	6.03	5.27	5.18	4.02	4.98	3.76	1.77
Moderate Democrat	213	7.22	6.01	5.23	5.16	4.01	4.88	3.78	1.82
Strong Democrat	263	7.11	6.09	5.29	5.18	4.05	4.98	3.86	1.80
Other	19	5.47	4.45	4.55	4.53	3.32	3.63	3.13	1.68
Average CSAT scores for self-reported gender									
Gender	No. of Obs.	Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov
Female	535	7.30	6.17	5.28	5.20	4.05	5.03	3.85	1.81
Male	444	7.33	6.17	5.25	5.18	4.12	5.07	3.86	1.81
Other	24	5.42	4.69	4.51	4.29	3.04	3.77	2.96	1.54
Average CSAT scores for self-reported ethnicity									
Ethnicity	No. of Obs.	Anderson and Sullivan (1993)	ACSI	Oliver (1980)	Oliver (2006 a)	Mittal and Kamakura (2001)	Oliver (2006 b)	Keiningham et al. (2007)	YouGov
Black	110	7.53	6.44	5.41	5.39	4.26	5.48	4.08	1.88
Asian	84	7.24	6.33	5.21	5.17	4.05	4.96	3.84	1.82
White	711	7.25	6.05	5.24	5.16	4.05	4.97	3.80	1.80
Hispanic	71	7.39	6.39	5.26	5.07	4.00	5.07	3.86	1.79
Other	27	6.56	5.76	4.99	4.88	3.67	4.30	3.54	1.74

Note: The sample of 1,003 customers rated a brand from a randomly assigned category (laptop, bank, auto, mobile service). The items are shown in Table 2

consequences of CSAT. Thus, conceptually and operationally, customer engagement overlaps with customer loyalty and is distinct from CSAT. Instead, customer engagement is best considered a consequence of CSAT.

CSAT versus customer loyalty Customer loyalty represents a constellation of intentions and behaviors emanating from CSAT. As Table 2 shows, *customer loyalty intentions* include survey-based measures such as repurchase intentions (Mittal & Kamakura, 2001), WOM intentions (Anderson, 1998), intent to recommend (Keiningham et al., 2007), and willingness to pay more (Anderson, 1996; Homburg et al., 2005). *Customer loyalty behaviors* use secondary, behavioral, and accounting data such as actual repurchases (Mittal & Kamakura, 2001) and share of wallet (Cooil et al., 2007). Loyalty intentions and behaviors are positively correlated, though the strength and functional form of the relationship vary (Mittal & Kamakura, 2001).

CSAT versus customer experience According to Grewal et al. (2009, p. 1), "customer experience includes every point of contact at which the customer interacts with the business, product, or service." Verhoef et al. (2009, p. 32) stated that the "customer experience construct is holistic in nature and involves the customer's cognitive, affective, emotional, social and physical responses…. [It] encompasses the total

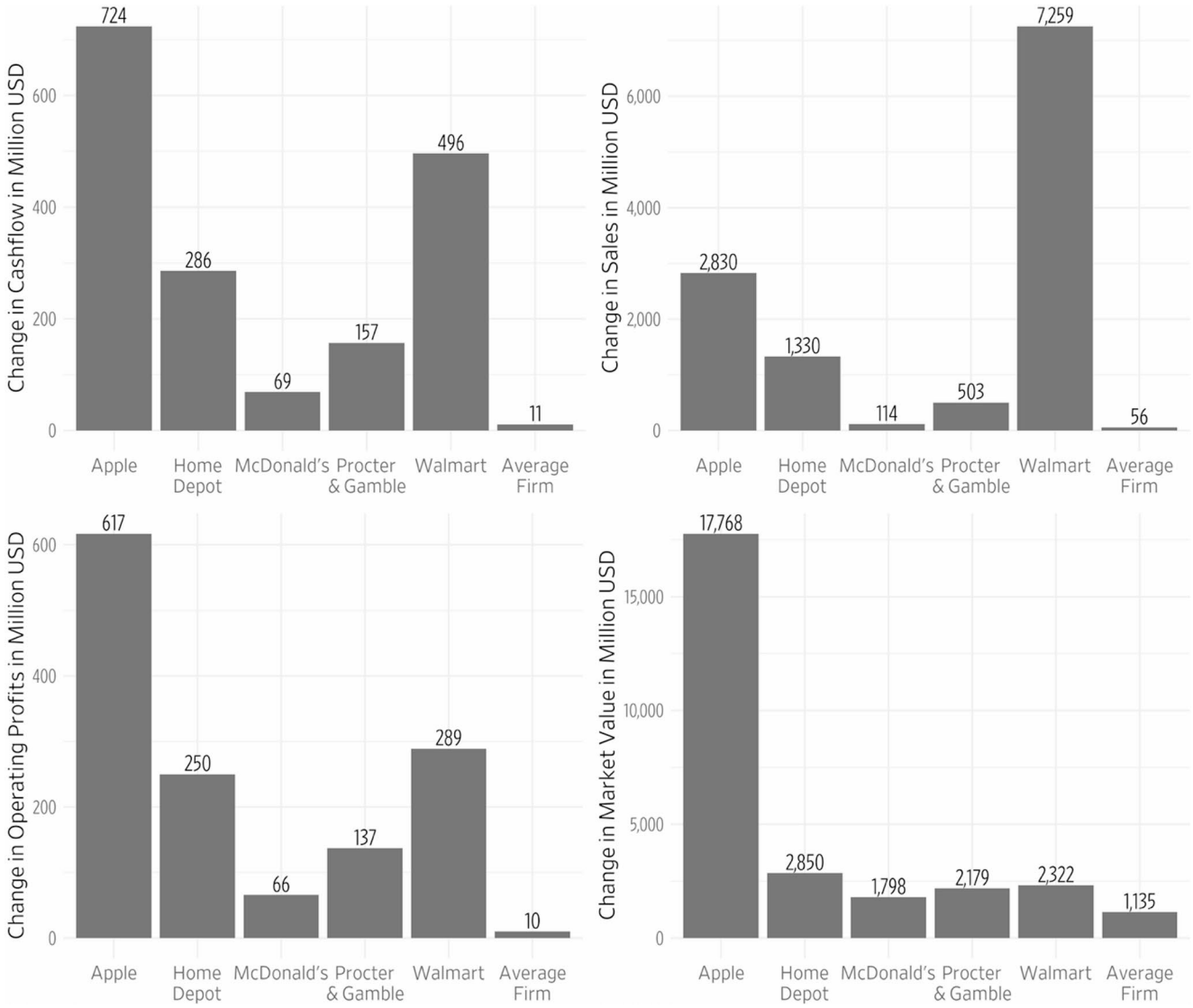


Fig. 1 Economic impact of customer satisfaction (CSAT) for individual firms

experience, including the search, purchase, consumption, and after-sale phases of the experience, and may involve multiple … channels." Thus, customer experience involves the management and measurement of the *different attributes* of customers' *multiple encounters* with an offering to gauge their effect on CSAT, customer loyalty, and firm outcomes. For example, Mittal et al. (1999) examined customer experience with the purchase and service experience with automobiles at different points in time. They measured CSAT with (1) the automobile as a function of attributes such as reliability and styling and (2) the dealership service with attributes such as honesty and cost. They found that the relative weights of different attributes shifted over time, providing strategy guidance to executives for managing customer experience.

CSAT versus customer value According to Woodruff (1997, p. 139), "customer value is a customer's perceived preference for and evaluation of those product attributes, attribute performances, and consequences arising from use that facilitate (or block) achieving the customer's goals and purposes in the use situation." Thus, CSAT and customer value are overlapping constructs representing a customer's summary judgment of an offering's ability to meet and exceed its promised goals after use. As customer value and CSAT tap into the same summary judgment, firms and scholars can

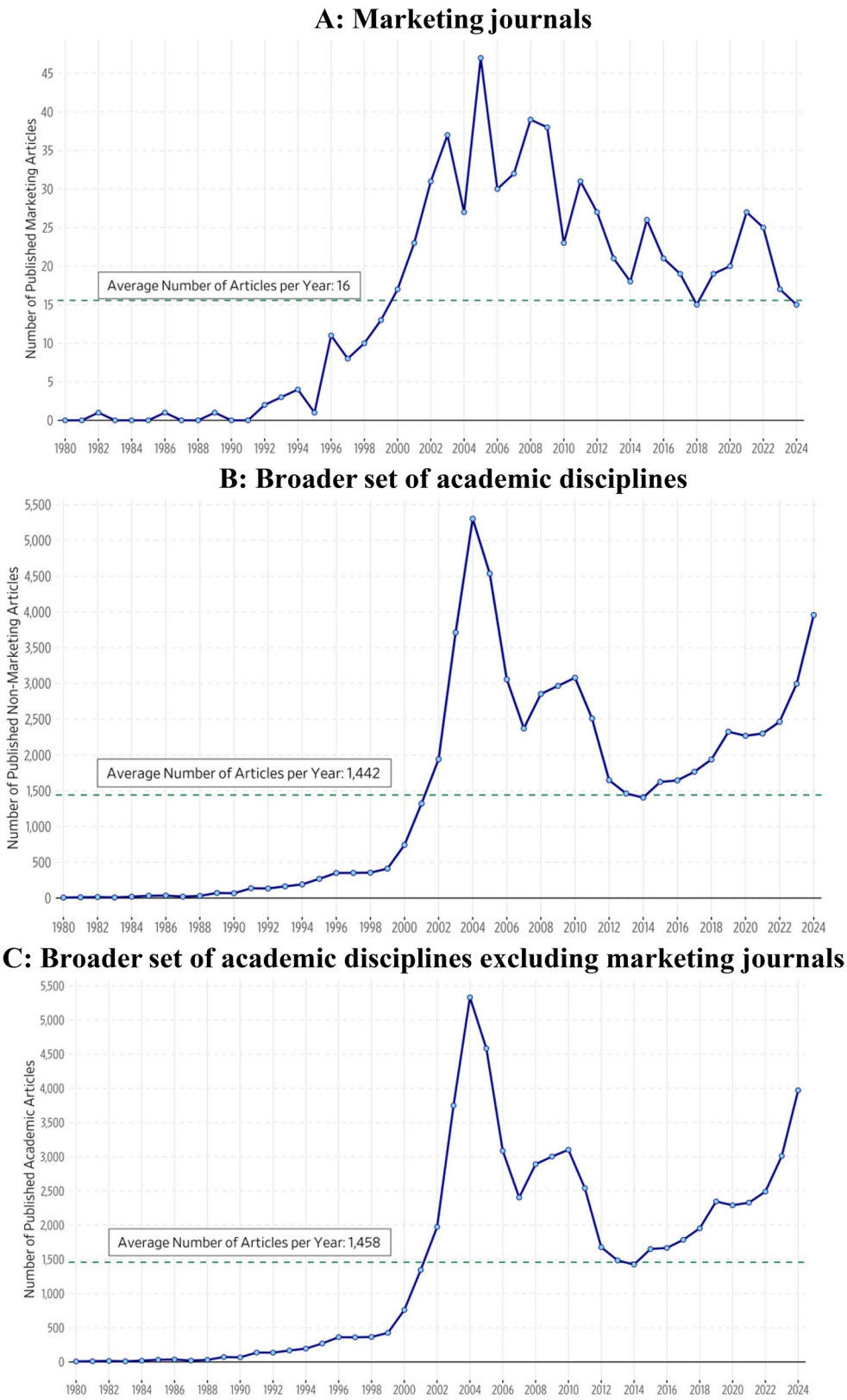


Fig. 2 Customer Satisfaction (CSAT) publications over time. Marketing journals: Journal of Marketing, Journal of Marketing Research, Journal of Consumer Research, Marketing Science, Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science, Management Science, Journal of Retailing, Journal of Service Research, International Journal of Research in Marketing, Marketing Letters and Journal of Business Research

use CSAT as a valid and reliable empirical measure of customer value. Strategically, CSAT provides a framework to assess the antecedents and consequences of customer value.

Conclusion

Service quality, customer engagement, customer loyalty, and customer experience are conceptually distinct from CSAT, though positively associated with it. Customer value overlaps with CSAT while (1) quality is an antecedent of CSAT, (2) engagement and loyalty are consequences of CSAT, and (3) customer experience includes transaction-level components of CSAT.

Using quality, engagement, experience, and loyalty interchangeably with CSAT can lead to conceptual confusion. For example, as we show subsequently, CSAT reliably predicts 12 critical customer and financial outcomes. Yet, to our knowledge, no evidence shows that service quality, customer engagement, or customer experience can predict these 12 critical outcomes. Still, many scholars and managers (incorrectly) believe that they can use service quality or customer engagement for strategy and financial planning. More critically, customer value and CSAT have a high degree of conceptual overlap. In any organization, CSAT can provide a valid, reliable, and useful framework to measure, create, and implement a strategy based on customer value.

Historical evolution of CSAT research

Customer satisfaction has a venerable history across multiple disciplines, including psychology, sociology, economics, accounting, entrepreneurship, finance, marketing, operations management, and strategy. This section provides a historical overview with exemplar articles (see Web Appendix C for a summary).

Historical timeline

Pre-1980: Exploring the terrain The founding meeting of the Operations Research Society (Page, 1952, p. 21, emphasis added) explicitly acknowledged the importance of CSAT, stating, "where there are two or more incommensurable goals the only real resolution of the problem is to recognize a higher order goal under which the others become comparable. In this case the higher order goal might be something like *customer satisfaction*, *which would combine both quality of transmission and cost*." Almost two decades later, Kotler and Levy (1969) compared the "old sense of 'pushing' products" to the new sense of "customer satisfaction engineering" (p. 10), bemoaning that disciplines such as marketing are viewed as "selling, influencing, persuading," when they should really be focused on "sensitively *serving and satisfying human needs*" (p. 15). Skinner (1969) argued that CSAT should be incorporated in a firm's manufacturing and corporate strategy, and Czepiel and Rosenberg (1977) proposed a conceptual model to define and measure CSAT.

Concurrently, a rich stream of empirical research emanated. Cadotte (1979) proposed a push-button survey for CSAT measurement in retail settings. Cardozo's (1965) experimental study showed that customers were more satisfied when they expended higher effort in acquiring a product. Bell (1967) examined the effect of customer characteristics and salesperson's persuasion attempts on post-purchase satisfaction. Esbensen (1973) employed CSAT as metric to hold public schools accountable to parents. Pickle and Rungeling (1973) examined the association among a firm's strategy, CSAT, and profitability. These early studies clearly demonstrated the relevance and usefulness of CSAT as a strategic framework for non- and for-profit organizations.

1980–2000: Nomological net Oliver (1980) articulated the role of expectations and disconfirmation in CSAT judgments. Later studies expanded the nomological net to include antecedents and correlates, such as emotions (Mano & Oliver, 1993), social norms (Cadotte et al., 1987), regret (Tsiros & Mittal, 2000), attributions (Folkes, 1988; Tsiros & Mittal, 2000), trust (Garbarino & Johnson, 1999), commitment (Keiningham et al., 2015), and relative equity (Oliver & Swan, 1989). LaTour and Peat (1979) developed an attribute-level model that studies later used to explore attribute-level non-linearities (Mittal et al., 1998), temporal shifts (Mittal et al., 1999), geographic variability (Mittal et al., 2004), and demographic and attitudinal variability (Oliver & DeSarbo, 1988) in predicting overall/global CSAT.

This research established CSAT as a well-defined, theoretically important, and managerially useful construct with a high degree of internal and discriminant validity with unique antecedents and consequences. Methodologically, these studies used cross-sectional surveys, longitudinal studies, panel studies, experiments, conjoint studies, and in-depth interviews. Conceptually, they established the complexity of the relationships as non-linear and asymmetric, moderated by contextual factors and mutable over time, geography, and customer background factors.

2000–2010: Consequences of satisfaction With CSAT's nomological net explicated, the next decade of research was

managerially oriented. It used firm-specific and industry-level datasets with large sample sizes, high external validity, and considerable managerial relevance.

Scholars examined the association of CSAT with WOM likelihood (Anderson, 1998), price tolerance (Anderson, 1996), share of wallet (Keiningham et al., 2003), repurchase intentions and behaviors (Mittal & Kamakura, 2001), recommendation likelihood (Finn et al., 2009), and complaint behavior (Haverila & Naumann, 2010). Others examined financial outcomes, including store traffic and revenue growth (Babakus et al., 2004), customer revenue (Terpstra et al., 2012), customer spending (Fornell et al., 2010), and retail sales (Gomez et al., 2004). Mittal and Frennea (2010) provide a systematic review of these studies.

2000–current: Satisfaction–performance chain as an integrated approach to strategic management Inspired by paradigms such as the satisfaction–performance chain (Anderson & Mittal, 2000; Kamakura et al., 2002; Rucci et al., 1998) and return on quality (Rust et al., 1995), scholars used data from a single firm to link CSAT surveys measuring attribute performance, overall satisfaction, and loyalty intentions with actual customer-level behaviors and sales, firm investments in satisfaction-enhancing activities, employee surveys, and measures of contextual factors (e.g., competitor scores). Studies traced the entire chain of effects from firm investments in attribute-level factors, to attribute performance ratings, overall satisfaction, and loyalty intentions and actual behaviors, to financial outcomes such as sales, profits, and market share. For example, examining the banking industry, Kamakura et al. (2002) showed how investments in tellers and automated teller machines at different branches influenced customers' attribute ratings of technology and customer service, which affected CSAT and revenue and margins at the branch level. Investments in tellers and technology had a direct negative effect on financial outcomes in addition to the positive effects mediated by attribute-level and overall CSAT ratings. Finally, bank branches that efficiently leveraged investments in tellers and technology to satisfy customers also had relatively higher financial performance. Studies also incorporated employee satisfaction ratings as an antecedent of CSAT (Evanschitzky et al., 2012). Sectors such as education (Mittal & Jung, 2024), travel agencies (Homburg et al., 2009), banking (Loveman, 1998), business-to-business (Bowman & Narayandas, 2001), and coffee shops (Son et al., 2021) have used this approach.

Industry adoption grew after articles in the *Harvard Business Review* identified CSAT as a foundational approach to strategic management (Heskett & Schlesinger, 1994; Rucci et al., 1998). Over time, this research was critically evaluated in review articles (Anderson & Mittal, 2000; Frennea et al., 2014) and summarized in a meta-analysis (Hogreve et al., 2017).

2000–current: Satisfaction–finance interface The ACSI ushered in the age of CSAT–finance interface research (Anderson & Fornell, 2000; Fornell et al., 1996; Morgeson et al., 2023), as it provided quarterly, firm-level CSAT ratings for publicly traded companies in different industries. By merging quarterly, firm-level satisfaction ratings with firm characteristics and financial outcomes, scholars could empirically assess the financial impact of CSAT by conceptualizing it as a unique and inimitable resource for firms (Barney, 1991; Wernerfelt, 1984).

Studies linked CSAT with Tobin's q (Anderson et al., 2004; Grewal et al., 2010), customer spending (Fornell et al., 2010), stock returns (Aksoy et al., 2008; Fornell et al., 2016; Keiningham et al., 2007; Morgeson et al., 2024), firm efficiency (Mittal et al., 2005), short selling (Malshe et al., 2020), cost of debt (Anderson & Mansi, 2009), cost of selling (Lim et al., 2020), stock risk (Tuli & Bharadwaj, 2009), market share (Rego et al., 2013), analyst recommendations (Luo et al., 2010), institutional ownership (Luo et al., 2014), and advertising efficiency (Luo & Homburg, 2007).

CSAT and its outcomes: Meta-analytic evidence

Recent meta-analyses have examined and reinforced the robust association of CSAT with customer loyalty and financial outcomes (Mittal et al. 2023a; Otto et al. 2020; Szymanski and Henard 2001). Table 5 summarizes the key associations in these three meta-analyses.

Reassuringly, all associations have similar magnitudes across the three meta-analyses in Table 5, attesting to their relative stability over time. In all three meta-analyses, CSAT is positively and reliably associated with customer-level outcomes, such as retention and WOM, and with firm-level outcomes, such as sales, revenue, profit, Tobin's q, and stock returns. The evidence for market share is weaker (close to zero and statistically non-significant).

Large-scale replication of CSAT outcomes

To replicate these meta-analyses, we constructed a dataset of CSAT ratings provided by YouGov from January 2007 to June 2023 and firm financial information from Compustat and CRSP. We followed Malshe et al. (2020) to create the overall dataset. The final dataset spans 16.5 years with

Table 5 Association of CSAT and its outcomes from meta-analyses in marketing journals

Outcome	Szymanski and Henard (2001)	Otto et al. (2020)	Mittal et al. (2023)
Customer-Level Outcomes			
Retention	$r=0.52$* ($n=5{,}066$; k=17)		$r=0.60$*** ($n=738{,}861$; k=191)
WOM	$r=-0.57$* ($n=1{,}170$; k=5) (negative WOM)		$r=0.68$*** ($n=104{,}979$; k=107) (positive WOM)
Complaining	$r=-0.34$* ($n=580$; k=4)		
Spending			$r=0.28$*** ($n=88{,}674$; k=44)
Price premium			$r=0.39$*** ($n=68{,}511$; k=15)
Firm-Level Outcomes			
Market share		$r=-0.019$ ($n=10{,}161$; k=23)	$r=0.05$ ($n=14{,}288$; k=16)
Sales/revenue		$r=0.092$* ($n=44{,}380$; k=97)	$r=0.15$*** ($n=33{,}444$; k=32)
Profit		$r=0.127$* ($n=41{,}821$; k=97)	$r=0.10$*** ($n=25{,}932$; k=28)
Return on assets (ROA)			$r=0.22$*** ($n=13{,}833$; k=25)
Cash flow level			$r=0.09$* ($n=6{,}821$; k=14)
Cash flow variability			$r=-0.10$*** ($n=14{,}055$; k=10)
Tobin's q		$r=0.263$* ($n=10{,}138$; k=30)	$r=0.29$*** ($n=14{,}047$; k=20)
Stock returns		$r=0.113$* ($n=13{,}966$; k=34)	$r=0.08$** ($n=19{,}595$; k=19)
Stock risk			$r=-0.23$*** ($n=13{,}246$; k=12)
Cost of debt financing			$r=-0.14$** ($n=4{,}696$; k=2)

*$p<0.05$; **$p<0.01$; ***$p<0.001$. Note: n=sample size; k=number of effect sizes

a sample of 17,001 firm-year-quarter observations based on CSAT scores from more than 285 million ratings across 1,126 brands from 458 publicly listed firms. To date, this is the most comprehensive and largest dataset relating CSAT to its outcomes. Web Appendix D describes the sampling frame, CSAT measure, and study description, including the model specification and estimation approach.

All regression models include firm size (measured as the natural logarithm of total assets), competitive intensity (measured using the Herfindahl–Hirschman Index), industry demand growth (using Han et al.'s (2017) approach), and financial leverage as control variables. The regressions predicting abnormal returns and Tobin's q include profit margin. We address endogeneity with a control function correction using one quarter lag of CSAT as an instrumental variable. We replicate the results with an internal instrument from a Gaussian copula (Park & Gupta, 2012).

We estimated 12 hierarchical models predicting two customer loyalty outcomes (recommendation and purchase intent), six accounting outcomes (sales, profit margin, ROA, cash flow, cash flow volatility, and market share), and four stock market outcomes (systematic risk, idiosyncratic risk, abnormal returns, and Tobin's q). We summarize the results in Table 6. As we show, they largely replicate the findings from the meta-analyses in Table 5. A firm's CSAT, operationalized as the log of percentage of its satisfied customers, is positively associated with likelihood to recommend (0.653, $p<0.01$), purchase intent (0.554, $p<0.01$), log of sales (0.088, $p<0.05$), profit margin (0.107, $p<0.05$), ROA (0.002, $p<0.05$), cash flow (0.112, $p<0.05$), market share (0.003, $p<0.01$), abnormal returns (0.016, $p<0.05$), and Tobin's q (0.143, $p<0.05$). CSAT is negatively associated with cash flow volatility (–0.247, $p<0.01$), systematic risk (–0.042, $p<0.01$), and idiosyncratic risk (–0.001, $p<0.01$). Notably, the results differ for market share: prior meta-analyses report weak or non-significant associations, though Table 6 shows a positive and statistically significant association between CSAT and market share.

To demonstrate the practical relevance of these results, we estimated the economic impact of a one-percentage-point change in the proportion of satisfied customers for a representative firm in our sample with quarterly cash flow of $1.5 billion, operating profits of $1.5 billion, sales of $10 billion, and total assets of $125 billion (approximating the average firm in our sample). On average, 15.75% of consumers report being satisfied with the brand. Consequently, a one-percentage-point change in the proportion of satisfied customers represents a strategically meaningful shift.

As our estimation approach employs a hierarchical model, we obtain firm-specific random coefficients for CSAT, use them to calculate the economic impact, and show the impact for a subset of firms in seven sectors (see Fig. 1 for the results and Web Appendix E for the approach). Apple, with 18% satisfied customers in the final quarter of the sample period (i.e., Q2 of 2023), would see its market value increase by $17.8 billion from a one-percentage-point increase in satisfied customers. Similarly, Walmart would

Table 6 Association of customer satisfaction (CSAT) with customer loyalty, accounting outcomes, and stock market outcomes

	Recommend	Purchase Intent	Log(Sales)	Profit Margin	ROA	Cash Flow	Cash Flow Volatility	Market Share	Systematic Risk	Idiosyncratic Risk	Abnormal Returns	Tobin's q
Intercept	1.020***	-0.299***	0.459***	-0.822***	0.025***	-0.598**	0.982***	-0.046***	0.791***	0.047***	-0.002	1.622***
	(0.019)	(0.025)	(0.059)	(0.196)	(0.003)	(0.252)	(0.363)	(0.001)	(0.045)	(0.002)	(0.007)	(0.131)
Log(% satisfied customers)	0.653***	0.554***	0.088**	0.107**	0.002**	0.112**	-0.247***	0.003***	-0.042***	-0.001***	0.016**	0.143**
	(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.037)	(0.042)	(0.001)	(0.053)	(0.070)	(0.001)	(0.010)	(0.000)	(0.007)	(0.062)
Firm size	0.006***	0.017***	0.693***	0.052***	-0.002***	0.030	0.009	0.005***	0.028***	-0.003***	0.001	-0.059***
	(0.002)	(0.002)	(0.005)	(0.016)	(0.000)	(0.021)	(0.028)	(0.000)	(0.004)	(0.000)	(0.016)	(0.015)
HHI	-0.571***	-0.056	1.654***	-0.145	-0.035**	-0.294	-0.956	0.213***	-0.094	0.009	-2.082**	-2.208***
	(0.085)	(0.135)	(0.257)	(1.220)	(0.016)	(1.546)	(2.079)	(0.006)	(0.271)	(0.008)	(1.033)	(0.706)
Industry demand growth	0.176***	0.060*	1.888***	4.102***	0.076***	4.449***	-5.327***	-0.003*	-0.147	-0.015***	0.198	2.284***
	(0.026)	(0.035)	(0.078)	(0.487)	(0.005)	(0.623)	(1.258)	(0.002)	(0.103)	(0.003)	(0.405)	(0.220)
Financial leverage	-0.056***	0.032***	-0.161***	-0.120	0.001	-0.253**	0.557***	-0.003***	0.081***	0.006***	-0.119*	0.720***
	(0.006)	(0.008)	(0.018)	(0.101)	(0.001)	(0.128)	(0.198)	(0.000)	(0.022)	(0.001)	(0.071)	(0.051)
Control function correction	0.107***	0.226***	-0.067**	-0.225	0.005**	-0.326	-6.720***	-0.001	0.029	-0.000	-0.076	-0.174*
	(0.011)	(0.016)	(0.033)	(0.227)	(0.002)	(0.302)	(0.702)	(0.001)	(0.046)	(0.001)	(0.063)	(0.092)
Profit margin											-0.003	0.010***
											(0.002)	(0.003)
No. of obs. (firm-year-quarter)	17,001	12,832	17,001	17,001	17,001	16,576	16,622	17,001	16,973	16,973	16,505	16,973
No. of firms	458	449	458	458	458	447	448	458	458	458	446	458
No. of responses (*in million*)	285.28	226.23	285.28	285.28	285.28	274.82	276.47	285.28	284.92	284.92	283.55	284.92
R^2 marginal	0.464	0.563	0.361	0.009	0.013	0.006	0.009	0.170	0.018	0.129	0.001	0.010
R^2 conditional	0.984	0.970	0.984	0.142	0.834	0.128	0.026	0.942	0.250	0.638	0.015	0.914

*$p<0.1$, **$p<0.05$, ***$p<0.01$. Note: Standard errors are in parentheses. All the explanatory variables in the regression with abnormal returns are unexpected changes in the respective variables estimated using AR(1) models. Firm size is the log of total assets for all the models except for abnormal returns and Tobin's q. For these two models, firm size is the log of sales. The coefficients of log(% satisfied customers) are random effects at the firm level. The intercept has random effects at the year-quarter level. R^2 marginal is the R^2 without random effects, and R^2 conditional is the overall R^2 including random effects. HHI = Herfindahl-Hirschman index

stand to realize a $7.26 billion increase in sales from a one-percentage-point increase in satisfied customers. These results reinforce the importance of using a strategy rooted in customer value measured by CSAT.

Conclusion

This historical overview shows the robust theoretical and conceptual underpinnings of CSAT research. Before 2000, research had a micro focus, borrowing from psychology and sociology to define the CSAT construct and its nomological net. After 2000, as firm-level data became available, meso studies examining CSAT within a firm became more prevalent, with ACSI providing inter-industry and economy-wide research insights.

The meta-analyses and empirical results attest to the validity and power of CSAT as the *only* customer-based construct (asset or resource) that can predict 12 critical financial and non-financial outcomes of strategic relevance. To our knowledge, no other construct (e.g., brand equity, service quality, customer engagement, customer experience) can reliably predict all 12 outcomes. The benefit of using CSAT as a core construct in marketing, strategy, organizational behavior, finance, accounting, and operations research is greater than ever.

Temporal trends in CSAT research and practitioner utilization

Trends in CSAT-related research publications

We assessed trends in CSAT-related research and its utilization among companies. Figure 2 shows the annual number of articles in the Scopus database that use the term "customer satisfaction" in their title, abstract, or keywords for three distinct groups of journals. Panel A comprises leading marketing journals, including *Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Marketing Research*, *Journal of Consumer Research*, *Marketing Science*, *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, *Management Science*, *Journal of Retailing*, *Journal of Service Research*, *International Journal of Research in Marketing*, *Marketing Letters*, and *Journal of Business Research*. Panel B shows all journals indexed in Scopus, including the marketing journals. Panel C includes all journals, excluding marketing journals.

As Panel A of Fig. 2 shows, CSAT publications steadily increased in marketing journals but peaked in 2005, followed by a steady decline. Panel B shows that CSAT publications in broader journals began rising steadily, peaked in 2005, then fell sharply, and resumed a steady increase from 2014. Panel C shows a negligible impact on the trend for the broader set of journals. We conclude that marketing journals have de-emphasized CSAT research since 2005, with other business journals increasing CSAT research since 2014.

Given the importance of CSAT in driving key consumer behaviors and financial outcomes, this decline in marketing journals is worrisome, raising several questions that need to be addressed. First, why has the stature of CSAT declined in marketing? Second, is marketing ceding its thought leadership position on CSAT to other disciplines? One reason for these anomalous patterns could be marketing's quest for newness at the expense of investing in its most effective ideas. Another reason could be marketing scholars' undue focus on CMOs as their key constituent at the expense of CEOs, CFOs, COOs, and CSOs. Marketing scholars often debate ways to strengthen the CMO's position in the C-suite. Yet, by de-emphasizing CSAT, marketing may be harming CMOs and their standing therein. Third, might de-emphasizing CSAT adversely affect marketing's position in business schools, among executives, and in the boardroom? Fourth, which constructs will the marketing discipline support and "own" to enable companies to become customer focused and improve performance? In general, marketing needs a health check with respect to CSAT scholarship. Collaborating with scholars in other disciplines may enable marketing to catch up to their lead in CSAT scholarship.

Trends in CSAT utilization among companies

We assessed the utilization of CSAT among firms in two ways. First, we constructed a measure of CSAT's utilization in a *firm strategy setting* as the percentage of US publicly listed firms within a year that mention the term "customer satisfaction" in their 10-K statement. According to prior research, 10-K statements are a credible and useful reflection of a firm's strategy as conceived by its senior management (Amel-Zadeh & Faasse, 2016; Li et al., 2013).[2] Some of the most successful firms (e.g., Nvidia Corp, Microsoft, Tesla) mention CSAT in their 10-K statements.

Second, we measured the utilization of CSAT in a *firm compensation setting* as the annual percentage of US publicly listed firms that use the term "customer satisfaction" in their definitive proxy statements (DEF 14 A), which provides information on bonus, profit sharing, and other compensation plans for company executives.[3] Accounting and finance scholars use DEF 14 A statements to obtain CEO bonus structures (Cheng et al., 2015) and executive

[2] This metric does not capture the number of mentions by each firm.

[3] https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-17/chapter-II/part-240/subpart-A/subject-group-ECFR8c9733e13b955d6/section-240.14a-101.

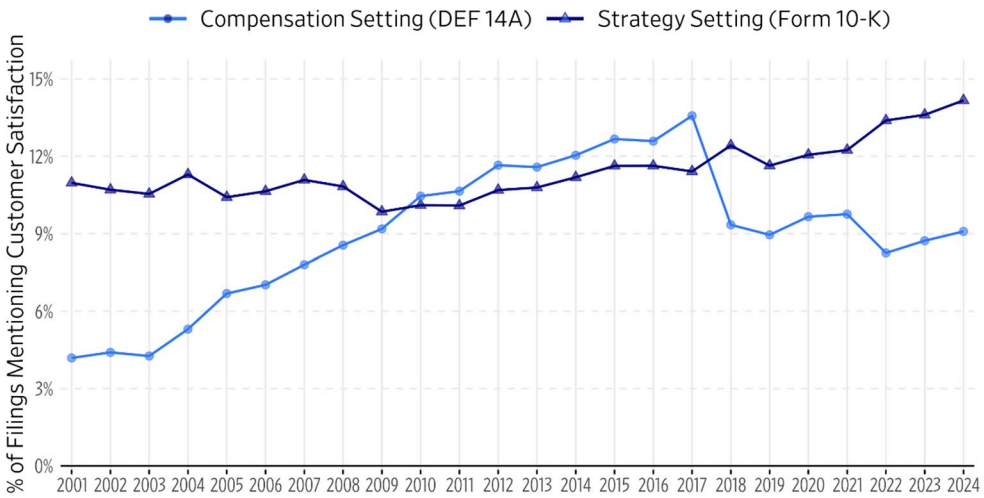


Fig. 3 Customer satisfaction utilization by firms

compensation (Larocque et al., 2020). Firms such as Adobe, Delta Airlines, and eBay mention CSAT in this form.

Figure 3 shows that the percentages of firms using CSAT in their strategy setting and compensation has increased annually between 2001 and 2024. The increase in CSAT utilization in strategy setting is modest (from ~11% to ~14%), while the increase in compensation setting is more pronounced (from ~4% to ~9%), after a decline in 2017.

Comparing academic and firm focus on CSAT

Figures 2 and 3 show that after 2014, firms increasingly used CSAT in strategy setting, with non-marketing journals paralleling the trend (Panel C of Fig. 2). It is worrisome that CSAT research in marketing journals has declined since 2014 (Panel A in Fig. 2). Firms show a decreased reliance on CSAT in compensation decisions since 2014. Sharing research that demonstrates the robust association between CSAT and financial outcomes could ameliorate this trend among firms.

Conclusion

We report temporal trends that are both positive and negative. On the positive side, CSAT has regained importance in setting strategy and executive compensation in firms and has gained a strong research footing among non-marketing disciplines. On the negative side, marketing scholarship has ceded its leadership in this area, lagging behind broader business disciplines and industry trends. A review team member asked if marketing is ceding leadership on the one issue that has gained visibility among CEOs, CFOs, COOs, and CSOs. The answer may be yes. There is a need to encourage new marketing scholars to capitalize on the promise and potential of CSAT research by revitalizing it and collaborating with scholars in other business disciplines.

With a robust nomological network supporting its construct validity and a well-developed set of reliable and valid measures, CSAT is a foundational cornerstone of scholarly research in many business disciplines. Importantly, CSAT clearly differs from seemingly related constructs, such as service quality, customer engagement, and customer experience. More notably, prior meta-analyses and the empirical analysis reported here firmly demonstrate that CSAT—not other constructs—is associated with 12 consequential customer loyalty, accounting, and stock market outcomes (see Table 6). We advise CEOs, CFOs, COOs, and CSOs to use CSAT in strategy planning, as it is the only construct that predicts important customer and financial outcomes while also providing a blueprint for developing, measuring, and executing a customer-focused strategy (Mittal et al., 2021).

CSAT: A multi-level integration and future research agenda

This section integrates CSAT research at the micro (individual consumer), meso (within a firm), and macro (across firms and including stakeholders) levels of analysis by developing three models. These models can help stimulate thought leadership and develop a unifying theory of CSAT as a strategic resource, specifying boundary conditions, moderating factors, and causal mechanisms that explain when and why satisfaction translates into outcomes for individuals, firms, industries, economies, and other stakeholders.

CSAT and individual consumers (micro-level framework)

Figure 4 shows an individual-level model rooted in a multi-attribute model of consumer utility (LaTour & Peat, 1979; Mittal et al., 1998). It integrates seminal models of CSAT's antecedents and consequences (Cardozo, 1965; Fornell, 1992; Fornell et al., 1996; Oliver, 1980, 2010, 2014; Tsiros & Mittal, 2000). Attribute-level expectations, performance, and disconfirmation are key antecedents of overall CSAT, which influences loyalty intentions and behaviors. Several factors directly influence CSAT and its antecedents and consequences and also moderate the associations among them.

We can classify the contextual factors into categories that are not mutually exclusive or collectively exhaustive but simply help to typologize constructs. First, social and psychological factors include affect and emotions (Mano & Oliver, 1993), perceived control (Namasivayam & Mount, 2006), political identity (Jung & Mittal, 2020), attributions of responsibility (Tsiros et al., 2004), and social comparisons (Bonifield & Cole, 2008; Halstead, 1999). Second, individual characteristics such as consumer age, sex, income, education, and marital status may influence focal constructs and their relationships (Peterson & Wilson, 1992). Third, factors related to competitors (Yang et al., 2022), industry differences (Gilbert & Veloutsou, 2006; Johnson et al., 2002), product versus services categorization (Anderson et al., 1997), regulatory issues (Bhattacharya et al., 2021), and economic environment (Morgeson et al., 2024) may be relevant. A fourth set of factors pertains to consumption contexts, such as private versus public consumption (Ratner & Kahn, 2002), extraordinary versus ordinary consumption experiences (Bhattacharjee & Mogilner, 2014), luxury versus non-luxury brands (Dubois et al., 2021), hedonic versus utilitarian categories (Pallas et al., 2014), serial consumption experiences (Mittal et al., 1999), and spatial heterogeneity in consumption contexts (Govind et al., 2018; Mittal et al., 2004). Finally, technological factors include online channels (Hult et al., 2019), digital consumption (Shankar et al., 2003), and artificial intelligence (AI) utilization (Barzizza et al., 2024).

The micro-level model includes key consumer-level outcomes, such as loyalty intentions and behaviors (Keiningham et al., 2007; Mittal & Kamakura, 2001; Oliver, 2014); evaluative judgments, such as regret (Tsiros & Mittal, 2000) and delight (Rust & Oliver, 2000); and emotional reactions (White & Yu, 2005). Research also documents the effect of merely measuring CSAT on consumer behaviors (Morwitz & Fitzsimons, 2004). The micro-level model incorporates contingencies among

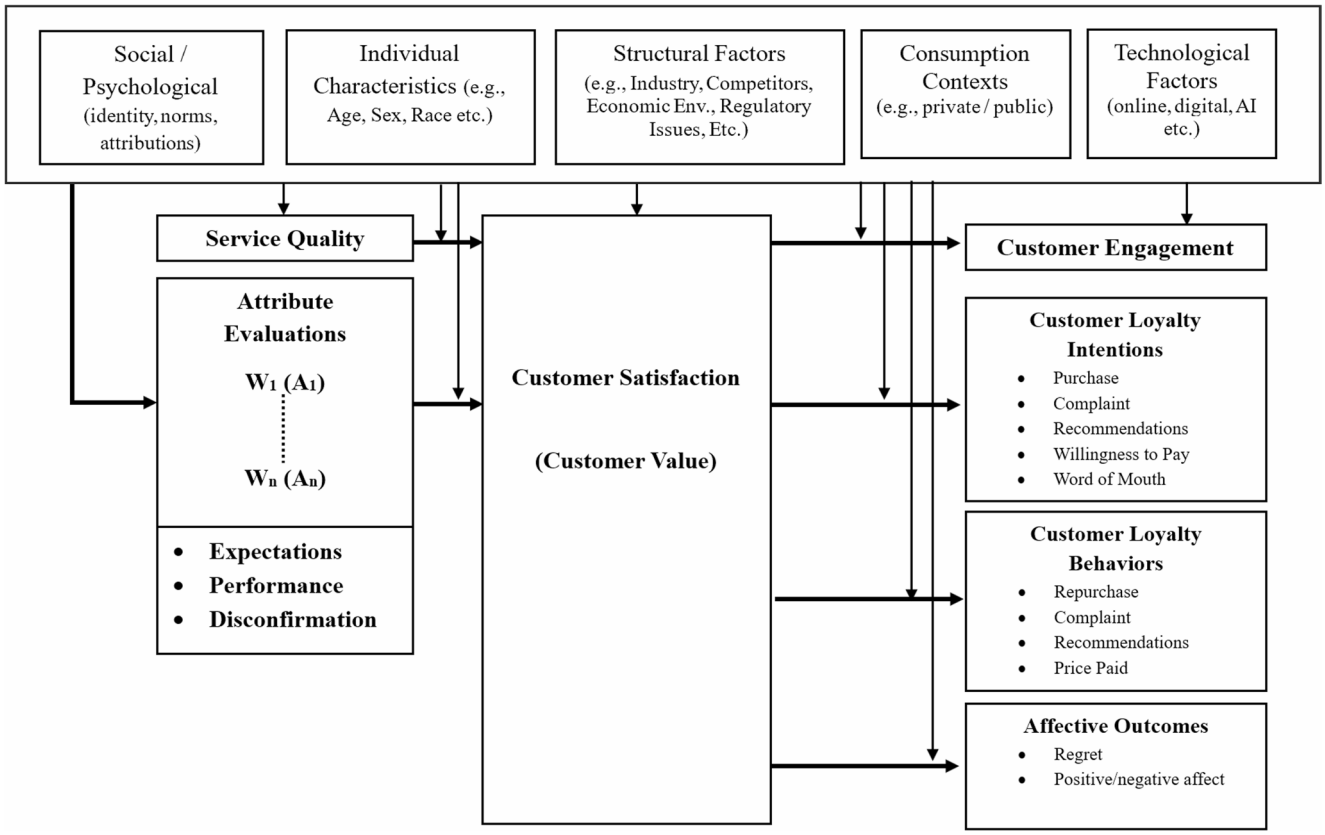


Fig. 4 Customer satisfaction and individual consumers (micro-level framework)

focal relationships that can vary over time, across geographies, and by customer, firm, industry, culture, and country characteristics. Many relationships are asymmetric and exhibit non-linear returns (Anderson & Mittal, 2000; Homburg et al., 2005; Mittal et al., 1998).

Future research The moderating effect of the contextual factors needs to be empirically re-examined to replicate and update known findings and generate new insights, such as through interactive effects of multiple contextual factors. Research can examine whether and how consumers' emotional states and social comparisons driven by social media information moderate attribute-level evaluations of performance jointly. For example, consumers might view online videos about others' experiences at a restaurant they had just visited, which may trigger emotional states that affect attribute evaluations and moderate their association with loyalty intentions and choice behaviors. Similarly, the use of generative AI during consumption should affect CSAT, such as when consumers use AI to obtain health-care advice or financial services (Whiles et al., 2023).

In monopolistic industries such as utilities, dissatisfied customers' ability to switch is not possible. To what extent may dissatisfied customers compensate for this inability by engaging in online complaining, and how can firms manage and respond to consumers' negative online activity (Herhausen et al., 2019)? Research can examine the joint and interactive role of different consumer identities in shaping CSAT and its effect on loyalty outcomes. While, in general, conservatives are more satisfied than liberals (Fernandes et al., 2022) and women more satisfied than men (Peterson & Wilson, 1992), is the joint effect of gender and political identity additive or multiplicative on CSAT and its association with key outcomes?

Digital consumption, social media, and AI are important research avenues for enhancing micro-level CSAT scholarship. Do customers who provide a higher number of positive online reviews or recommendations compensate by buying less from the company, and how does this compensatory effect vary among customers high or low in satisfaction? Future research is necessary to ascertain the additive and multiplicative effect of online reviews on CSAT formation and loyalty outcomes. When do CSAT ratings show an assimilation versus contrast effect with the tone, valence, and content of online reviews, and why? How do these effects manifest when consumers read individual reviews sequentially versus when they receive summary information (e.g., overall average score) for a brand? Research should also examine the effect of non-human service providers (e.g., robots, autonomous vehicles) on satisfaction and loyalty. How does CSAT differ when attribute performance suffers but the attribution for failure is made to a human versus non-human service provider? Research has widely examined these issues for pre-purchase decisions but less so in the context of CSAT (for an exception, see Mende et al., 2019). Finally, with the emergence of AI, yet-to-be-formulated questions will arise. We offer two here. Can AI predict the level of satisfaction a customer will experience after buying a product or service? How does AI utilization during the consumption experience affect CSAT, and does path dependency exist between CSAT ratings and AI utilization during consumption? Such questions address CSAT in a new-economy context.

Strategic CSAT management (meso-level framework)

Figure 5 shows a firm-level model for strategic CSAT management. Its foundations are rooted in systems theory (Reidenbach & Oliva, 1981) with critical concepts described in seminal models, including return on quality (Rust et al., 1995), satisfaction–performance chain (Anderson & Mittal, 2000), and service-profit chain (Hogreve et al., 2017). The satisfaction–performance chain conceptualizes a set of inputs, throughputs, and outputs. Each set includes both psychological (e.g., perceptions, judgments, intentions of firms' customers and employees) and instrumental (e.g., actual investments made by the firm, policies, actions, behavioral and financial outcomes) constructs.

Figure 5 depicts inputs, including controllable and uncontrollable factors at the firm and industry levels. Firm-level controllable input investments and processes affect actual performance of different attributes, which influence customer perceptions of attribute-level performance. For example, controllable inputs such as a bank's investment in technology may reduce waiting time at the teller, which in turn may affect customer perceptions of waiting time and, subsequently, CSAT. The focal bank's competitors' investments in waiting time may also influence customer evaluations, intentions, and behaviors.

As described in Frennea et al. (2014), the strategic model for a firm is empirically estimated using firm-specific data assembled from multiple sources: operations (attribute-level investments), marketing (customer surveys), accounting (customer-level sales and profit metrics), strategy (competitor information), human resources (employee satisfaction ratings), and finance (stock market performance), among others. The resulting resource-intensive dataset enables a firm to successfully increase value for customers, employees, and shareholders. Next, we briefly describe a real-life case study to illustrate the success of CSAT as a strategic framework.

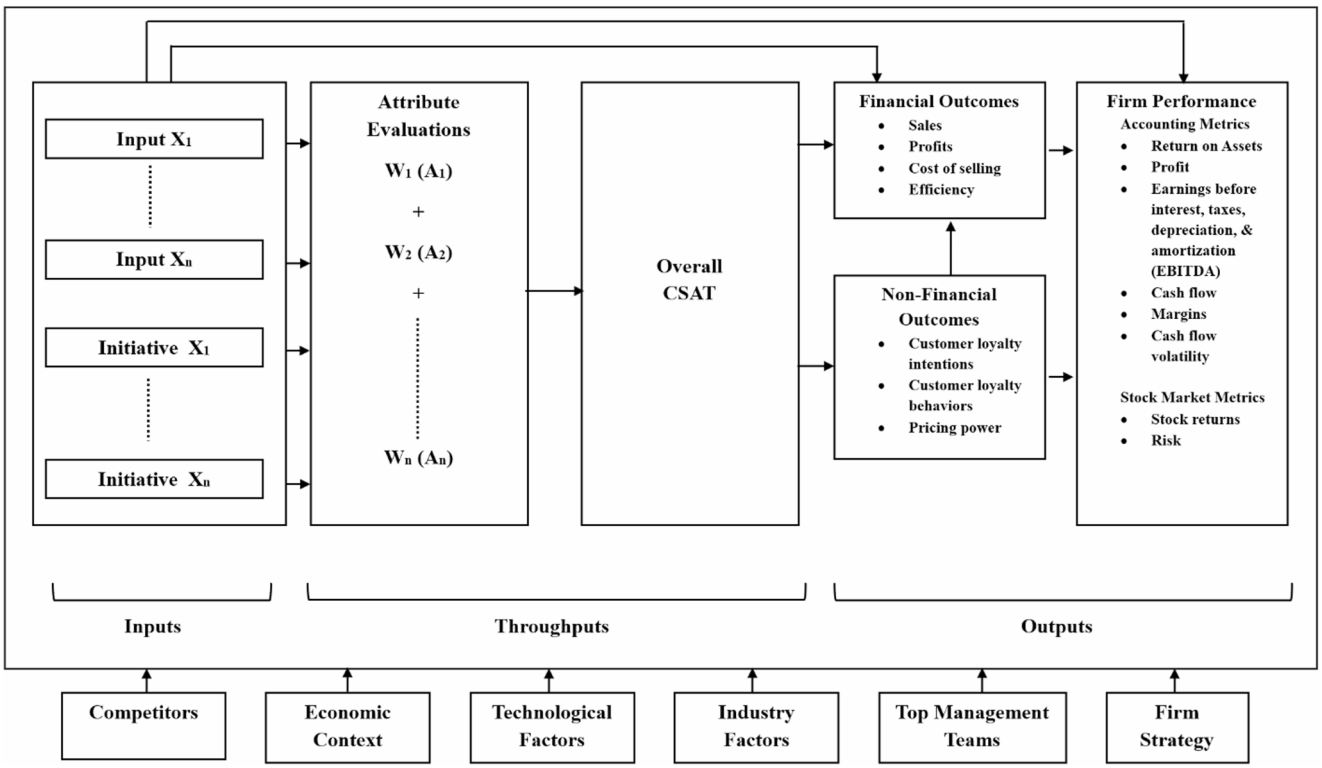


Fig. 5 Strategic customer satisfaction management by firms

Strategic satisfaction management at ITI Manufacturing, Inc. Eschewing legacy strategy planning, ITI Manufacturing's CEO implemented a customer-focused strategy. A customer survey showed that the highest lift in overall CSAT pertained to three strategic areas: product quality, ongoing service, and communication. Tracing back to specific attributes in each strategic area showed that providing weekly customer updates and resolving issues to customers' satisfaction had the highest lift. To the CEO's surprise, lower pricing and the sales process—two areas pushed by marketing—provided no lift in customer value (see Fig. 6a).

Along with the COO and CSO, the CEO worked to consistently provide a weekly update and to resolve 100% of customer issues. Within two quarters, every customer received a weekly update and 100% of customers' issues were resolved to their satisfaction. While the company persisted in this strategy, it also stopped many unrelated initiatives that did not enhance customer value. As shown in Fig. 6b, this strategy improved CSAT and loyalty intentions over time. As seen in Fig. 6c, the firm experienced an increase in sales (20.6% increase relative to an industry control group) and gross margins (18.6% increase). After four years, ITI Manufacturing's stock rose 115%, three times faster than the S&P 500; in the four years prior, its stock was virtually parallel with the S&P 500.

Future research First, prior studies have mostly used single-firm or single-industry data, with few, if any, examining the effect of competitor measures and activities to conceptualize different links for a focal firm. Research employing multi-firm surveys in the same industry should compare the chain of effects among different firms, identify differences among them, and explain them using critical moderators such as firm, top-management, and industry characteristics as well as differences in firm strategy. Explaining why the weights (i.e., regression coefficients) for the same linkage vary among competitors in the same industry (e.g., Walmart, Target, Costco) would be beneficial. Research should also explore the extent to which these differences result from strategic intent and intentional actions versus fixed firm and industry characteristics.

Second, most marketing studies have focused on customer surveys, with few linking actual operational investments to customer perceptions (for exceptions, see Bowman & Narayandas, 2001; Kamakura et al., 2002). Research should go beyond marketing and work with the entire C-suite to link firms' operational activities to customer perceptions of attribute performance and financial consequences to provide actionable strategic guidance. Third, research should incorporate new-economy outcomes, such as online reviews, in the strategic model. For example, how do online reviews

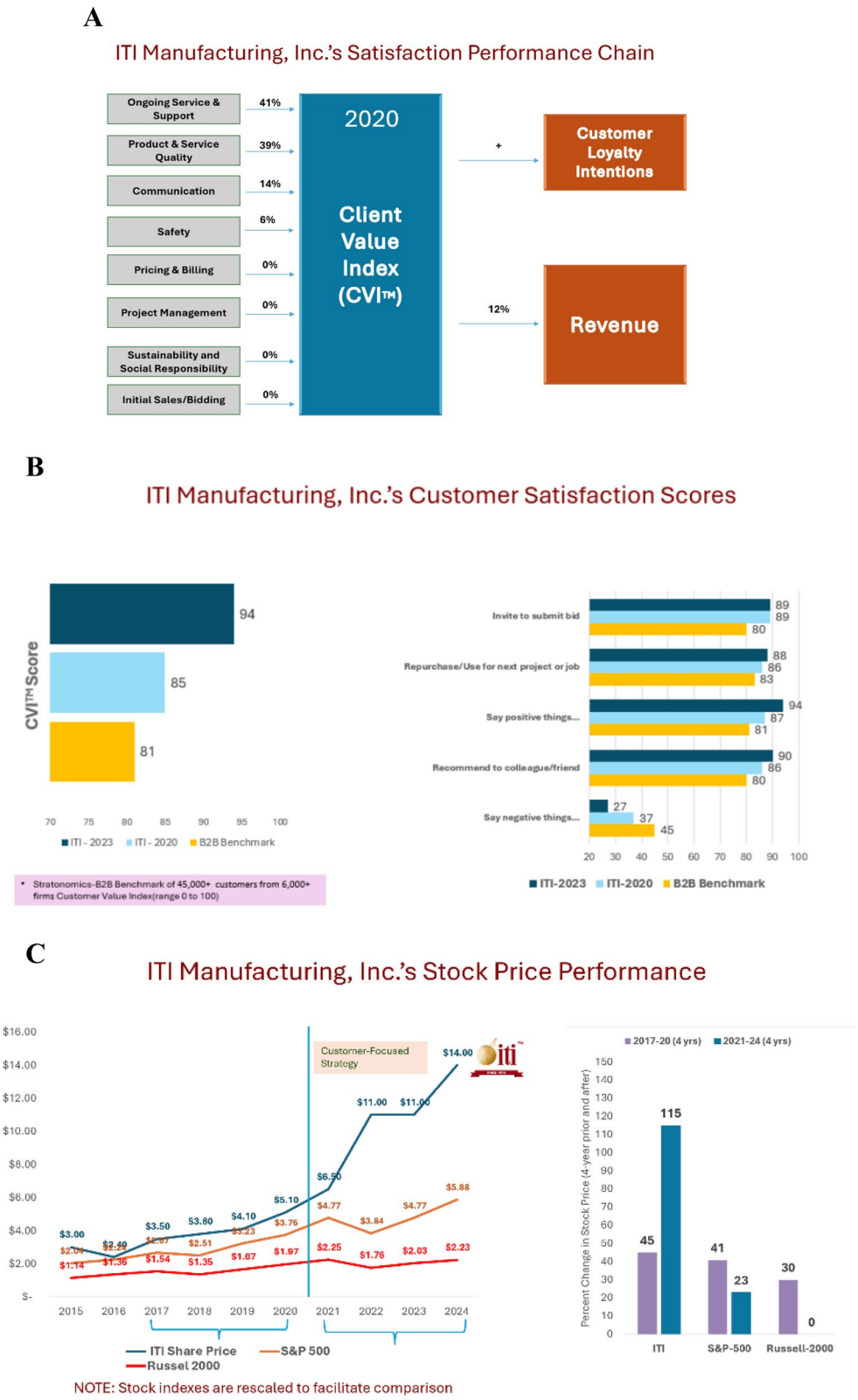


Fig. 6 **A** Strategic management of satisfaction–performance chain at ITI Manufacturing, Inc. **B** Customer satisfaction and customer loyalty at ITI Manufacturing, Inc. **C** Relative stock price for ITI Manufacturing, Inc. (vs. S&P 500 and Russell 2000)

of one firm affect CSAT and sales of its competitors? How and why do the satisfaction–performance chain links vary between online versus physical environments?

Fourth, how does the utilization of AI and robots affect operational inputs and their impact on attribute performance and overall satisfaction? Does using AI and robots directly affect firm sales and profitability, or do attribute-performance perceptions and CSAT mediate the effect? Do these technologies have countervailing effects that simultaneously improve efficiency (increasing margins) but reduce CSAT? Research should examine how and why the use of AI affects employees' ability to influence customers' perceptions of attribute performance. Fifth, the nature of the relationships in the strategic model can fundamentally change as firms incorporate AI in their employee- and customer-facing activities. The impact of AI adoption on employees' information processing and productivity should also be examined.

Sixth, research should more deeply examine managerial decision-making in a satisfaction context (Morgan et al., 2005). Little is known about managers' utilization of CSAT information in strategic decision-making. What is the best way to aggregate, display, and share CSAT information with boards, middle management, and frontline employees? What is the appropriate frequency of information sharing on CSAT? How will these facets of CSAT and strategic decision-making evolve with the adoption of AI?

Seventh, and relevant to the next section, research should incorporate the role and satisfaction of additional stakeholders, including employees, suppliers, and regulators, in the satisfaction–performance chain. It should also include environmental and societal outcomes as well as other non-financial outcomes of concern to a wide variety of constituents (e.g., life satisfaction scores of customers and non-customers). Eighth, research can explore reverse and reciprocal effects. For example, how does a firm's financial strength affect its ability to increase CSAT (Malshe & Agarwal, 2015), and how do attribute-performance perceptions drive firm investments?

Stakeholder management through CSAT (macro-level framework)

Moving beyond customers, the macro-level model includes shareholders, employees, competitors, suppliers, debtors, community members, and regulators. Figure 7 shows the expanded model.

Pertinent to financial stakeholders, we show the association of CSAT with 12 customer- and financial-outcomes critical for shareholder wealth maximization (see Table 6). In addition, a firm's debtors benefit from high CSAT because it lowers the firm's cost of debt (Anderson & Mansi, 2009) and bankruptcy risk (Naumzik et al., 2022). Other financial constituents, such as short sellers (Malshe et al., 2020) and financial analysts (Luo et al., 2010), also use CSAT information as a critical decision-making resource.

Pertinent to employees, CSAT and employee satisfaction affect each other (Evanschitzky et al., 2011, 2012; Groening et al., 2016; Hogreve et al., 2017). Most studies treat employee satisfaction as an antecedent of CSAT, such that CSAT mediates the effect of employee satisfaction on financial performance. Insofar as higher CSAT improves firms' financial performance, employees should be concerned with satisfying customers to increase their own compensation. Reciprocally, firms aiming to improve financial performance should focus on employee satisfaction, but as a means to increase CSAT, the main antecedent of financial performance (Damavandi et al., 2026). As Fig. 3 shows, many firms tie executive compensation to CSAT.

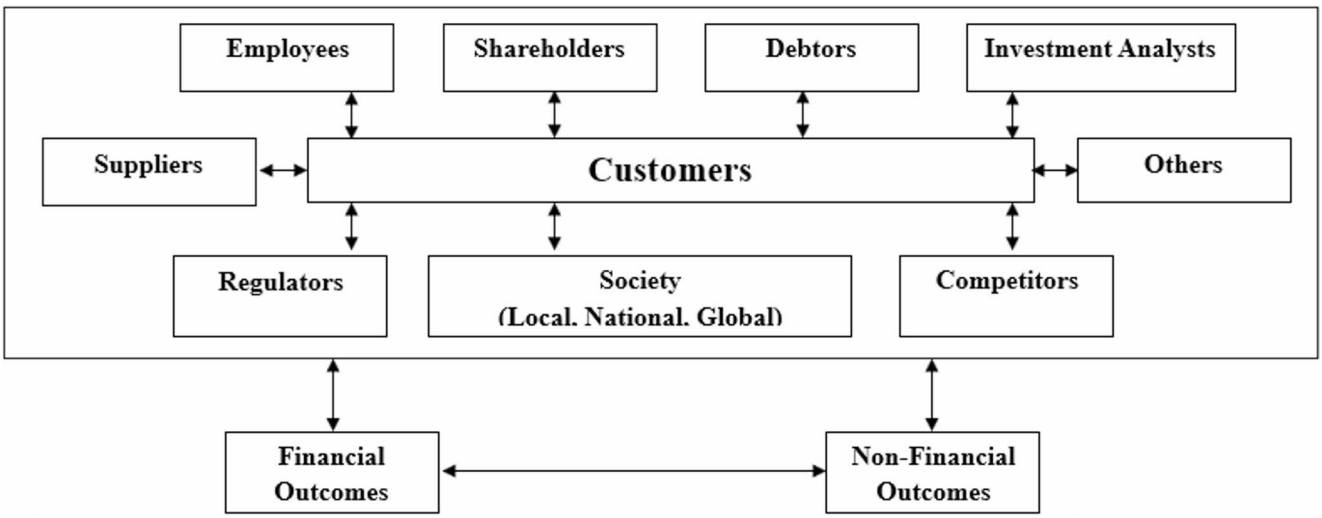


Fig. 7 Stakeholder management and customer satisfaction (macro-level framework)

Examination of the competitive effects of CSAT with a focal firm and its competitors remains an under-researched area, though it will require longitudinal data from multiple competitors over time. Higher CSAT with a focal firm can motivate rival firms to improve their offerings, thereby increasing the satisfaction level for non-customers of the focal firm; this is more likely in highly competitive industries. Competitively, if a focal firm's customers experience high satisfaction, customers of competitor firms may experience regret due to their relatively lower satisfaction. These effects may manifest faster and stronger in industries in which customers can gauge satisfaction with multiple brands (e.g., from online reviews or publicly available satisfaction data). Scholars can develop game-theoretic models of competition and test them using multi-competitor data. Today, CSAT ratings may be available for retailers as well as manufacturer brands. Such availability further provides an avenue to empirically test game-theoretic predictions of distribution models with bargaining.

Stakeholders in regulated industries find CSAT scores of immense interest. For example, regulators monitor and publicize satisfaction scores in sectors such as utilities (Bhattacharya et al., 2021), public schools (Mittal & Jung, 2024), health care (Govind et al., 2008; Mittal & Baldasare, 1996), and airlines (Grewal et al., 2010). Conceptually, using CSAT as a measure of consumer surplus (Anderson, 1996) provides a practical framework to assess consumer well-being in all these sectors and especially for life satisfaction (Sirgy et al., 2012). The association between CSAT and life satisfaction (Luan et al., 2022) should be ascertained and its moderators, such as consumer identity (e.g., Is the association stronger for conservatives versus liberals or men versus women?), social media consumption patterns, and marketing-mix factors (e.g., advertising; Wiles et al., 2024), examined. As CSAT is associated with increased customer spending (Fornell et al., 2010), regulators can use it to develop models predicting customer spending, a major driver of economic growth. CSAT indicates the extent to which consumers adapt by adjusting their market expectations over time (Johnson et al., 1995), giving meaningful information to policymakers. CSAT formation and measurement in these sectors will evolve as they embrace the use of AI, robots, and other digital technologies. For example, how do patients make satisfaction judgments when care is provided by robots? The use of AI to obtain information and aid consumers' choices can fundamentally change their choices and how they experience many services. Future studies can examine these aspects using both experimental and survey research.

In addition, regulators can use CSAT as a framework for several industry- and economy-level policy decisions. First, they can use CSAT to prospectively assess the cost versus benefit of mergers and acquisitions (Swaminathan et al., 2014; Umashankar et al., 2022). Second, CSAT with regulated utilities can inform policy, as it is associated with the relative efficacy and efficiency of utilities (Bhattacharya et al., 2021); regulators can not only use CSAT metrics to monitor utilities' ability to create customer value but also measure the extent to which they are using resources wisely. Prior research has established a link between corporate social responsibility and CSAT (Luo & Bhattacharya, 2006), but it can be expanded to include other societally relevant outcomes, such as sustainable business practices and the caring of vulnerable consumers. A critical regulatory area is the use of AI by different stakeholders. Research has investigated the role of AI utilization in driving CSAT (Aguiar-Costa et al., 2022; Patil 2024; Prentice et al., 2020), though more work should explore attribute-level effects. An even more important question is the impact of CSAT on AI utilization. Are more satisfied customers more (or less) prone to using AI in their daily lives and in consuming products and services, and what are its implications for shareholder (increased or decreased profits) and employee (potential job reductions) well-being?

Finally, non-human stakeholders, such as the environment and society (local, national, and international), could be the focus of conceptual models relating CSAT to societally relevant outcomes such as corporate environmental practices (Alyahya & Agag, 2025; Kassinis & Soteriou, 2003). Broadening the scope of CSAT research to multiple stakeholders can stimulate interdisciplinary research in the areas of strategy, operations management, economics, public policy, accounting, human resources, and finance. CSAT research stands to gain when scholars from a broader set of disciplines embrace it to ask multi-disciplinary questions and follow it with inter-disciplinary research. Finally, viewing companies as stakeholders of academics, research would benefit from collaborating with practitioners who can provide ideas, data, and insights.

Cross- and multi-level research at the micro, meso, and macro levels

Prior CSAT research questions have been typically confined to a specific level of analysis. Cross-level linkages represent a key research area. How do economy- and industry-wide shifts in CSAT and other constructs affect individual- and subgroup- level CSAT, and why? For example, previous research has measured the effect of firm-level CSAT on stock returns. Future research should examine how broader market returns affect consumers' CSAT with different brands and the resulting differences among brand and customer subgroups. Industry- and macro-level factors that affect

individual customers' CSAT scores should be explored as well.

Furthermore, research should examine whether and how variation in the weights of attributes across competitors affects satisfaction ratings across different customer subgroups. For example, Walmart customers may prioritize lower prices and variety, while Amazon customers may put more weight on fast delivery and online shopping. If Walmart increases its performance on fast delivery, how does this affect a customer's CSAT with its competitors? When CSAT with a brand, firm, or industry changes, what is the effect on the efficacy of different marketing-mix factors? Similarly, why and how might social media trends affect individual consumers' consumption patterns and satisfaction with offerings they consume? Research could also examine spillover effects across categories over time and space. For example, how does dissatisfaction with an airline flight affect a customer's satisfaction with the hotel at the final destination? In addition to relying solely on secondary data, scholars could run experimental studies to prime meso- and macro-level constructs through stimuli variation and then test their effects at the individual level.

Conclusion

We hope that this article inspires new scholars to embrace CSAT as a research area. No other known marketing construct can predict as many consequential outcomes as CSAT. CSAT is easy to measure and operationalize for utilization in all types of research, including consumer behavior (Mano & Oliver, 1993), strategy research (Aksoy et al., 2008; Lim et al., 2020), empirical models (Grewal et al., 2010; Huang & Sudhir, 2021), and even analytical models (Chu & Desai, 1995). Overall, the potential for CSAT research lies in scholars' interest in revitalizing CSAT as a source of value for multiple stakeholders given its various outcomes.

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